

VOLUME THREE

Depoldering

Sankt Annen, present day

The Reclaimed Land

A North Sea Saga



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Novel · written with Claude Opus

The Reclaimed Land - Depoldering

Drama / Family and Social Novel

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Chapter 1 - Return to the Coast

Wiebke Carstens came back to the coast on a day in late summer, and the first thing she saw was how near the water had come to the land. She had the gauge records in her bag and the commission to plan a depoldering, and she was engineer enough to know the figures before she measured them: the sea level was rising, faster than the old forecasts, the storm tides came higher and more often, and the dyke at the Sankt-Annen-Koog, old and not to be held in the long run, was on the list of sections one had to give up to save others. She was thirty-eight and had not been here since her childhood, not properly. Her mother had gone away from the marsh, as her mother Anke had gone away, and Wiebke had grown up in the city, had studied hydraulic engineering, had become a coastal engineer — and yet, when the road reached the dyke and she saw the warften lying flat over the land, and the dyke, and behind it the grey water, something contracted in her that she had believed long since left behind.

She put up in the village, in the only inn, and on the first evening she went out to the dyke. The Carstens warft still stood, up on the koog's rise, and on it her cousin Jan farmed, the heir to the farm, the son of Hinrich, the preserver. Wiebke barely knew him; the family had scattered, the line that left and the line that stayed greeted each other politely and as strangers.

In the village something swung along that Wiebke could not interpret: an old coldness when the name Carstens fell, a certain

silence, a not-quite-looking-at-each-other between certain families. She pushed it aside. She was not here to dig in family histories. She was here on account of a dyke that could no longer be held, and on account of a plan that many would not like.

For the word she brought was a word that awoke resistance in the koog: depoldering. It meant not to raise a dyke but to give it up; to build a new dyke further inland and give the land between back to the sea, to the water, to nature conservation. It meant giving the sea back what generations had wrested from it, and for the people of the marsh, whose whole history was a struggle for reclaimed land, that was almost a blasphemy: to give up land, voluntarily, to leave it to the water.

Wiebke stood at the dyke, in the last light, and looked over the land her forebears had won, and over the water that reclaimed it, and she knew that her work here would stir up more than just silt. She did not yet know how much more. She did not know that the land she was to give back to the sea included precisely that old foreland a flood had taken over a hundred years before, and that beneath the water she would let rise lay a sunken warft and with it the truth of her own family.

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Chapter 2 - The Cousin and the Land

Jan Carstens was a man in his forties, terse, stubborn, down-to-earth, a farmer who carried on the farm of his father Hinrich, as Hinrich had taken it from Bo. He received Wiebke politely and coolly, with the mistrust of the settled toward the incomer, even if the incomer was a Carstens. "So you want to give up the dyke," he said, when they sat in his kitchen, over the coffee his wife had poured. It was not a question, it was a reproach.

"I don't want to give it up," said Wiebke. "I want to save what can be saved. The old dyke can't be held in the long run, Jan. The water is rising. If we do nothing, it breaks at some point, in a heavy flood, and then we lose everything, uncontrolled. If we depolder, we give up one stretch, controlled, and secure the rest behind it. That's not giving up. That's strategy."

"It's giving up." Jan set the cup down. "The stretch you want to give up, that's my foreland. My best land, out before the dyke. My forefathers wrested that from the sea, generation by generation, with their hands. And you come from the city and want to give it back to the water, with a stroke of the pen." He looked at her. "Whoever will not dyke must yield, it always was with us. Now I suppose it means: whoever can dyke must yield all the same, because the city wills it so."

Wiebke knew the saying, she had heard it from her mother, who had it from Bo. And she saw the land with Jan's eyes for a moment: generations of work, sweat, hands in the silt, all of it given back to

the water. It was not incomprehensible, his anger. But she saw it also with the engineer's eyes: the foreland was deep, the dyke before it decrepit, the costs of its upkeep rising into the unaffordable, and the water rose further, unstoppable. It was not to be held, neither economically nor physically. That was no question of will. That was a question of gravity and of money.

"I understand what it means to you," she said. "But the water doesn't ask what it means to us. It rises. And we can choose whether we retreat in order or drown in disorder. We have no more choice than that."

Between the cousins it stayed at friction, and beneath the friction lay something else that Wiebke sensed and could not name: the old coldness that swung in the village when the name Carstens fell, a shadow over the family of which Jan too knew nothing exact and which was nonetheless there. Jan wanted to hold the land, not only from reason, but from something deeper, a bond to the soil that was almost religious — and Wiebke sensed that this bond itself was part of what had never let the family look, that the holding-on to the land and the concealing of an old guilt belonged together, even if she did not yet know how.

In the next days Wiebke began to research in the archive of the dyke and water board. She needed the historical gauge records, the old dyke files, the data on breaches and repairs, to underpin her plan. It was routine, preparation, number-work. She did not sense that she would in the process come upon something older than any gauge and deeper than any dyke: upon the year 1906, upon a faulty spot, upon a dead man and a name that was her own.

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Chapter 3 - The Records

The archive of the dyke and water board lay in a sober building in the county town, and Wiebke spent days in it, among shelves full of files that reached back into the last century. She sought the gauge records, the breach statistics, everything that supported her depoldering plan, and she was thorough, as she was always thorough, and so she read too what she had not sought. She found the protocols of the great storm tide of 1906. The breach at the Sankt-Annen-Koog was recorded in them, at length, for it had been a heavy breach, with dead and great land-loss. She read the cause assessment: a spring tide at standing northwest, a level beyond all marks, an act of God. She read of the dead man who had lost his life in the breach, in the dyke service: a man named Momme Feddersen, who had guarded the endangered spot. Feddersen. The name that triggered the coldness in the village.

She read on, and in the board archive she found not only the official protocols but also old dyke documents the board had taken over when the dyke-reeve administration was modernised — among them transcripts from the old dyke books of the koogs. And in the transcript of the Sankt-Annen dyke book she found an entry of 1906, in the old hand of a dyke-warden named Okke Nissen: the faulty spot by the sluice, patched and not thoroughly done, the dyke-reeve warned. And beneath it, after the breach: a dead man at the said spot.

Wiebke sat quite still. A faulty spot one knew of. A warning not heeded. A breach at precisely this spot. A dead man who guarded it. That was not an act of God. That was, at least in part, an omission —

a dyke-reeve who out of thrift had not had a known weakness repaired, and a man who died for it.

And the dyke-reeve of 1906? She sought it, in the board lists, and found it: dyke-reeve of the Sankt-Annen-Koog, 1901 into the twenties, was Hauke Carstens. Her great-grandfather. The man from whom the farm came that Jan sat on today, the land the family won. Hauke Carstens had not had the spot done at which Momme Feddersen drowned, and after the flood, the survey files showed, the Carstens farm had gained land where the Feddersens lost theirs — precisely that foreland that now, a hundred years later, Wiebke was to give back to the sea.

She remembered, all at once, something from her childhood: her mother, who had once told of her grandfather Bo, who had lain dying and talked confused stuff, of a "faulty spot" and of "Momme" and of a "book in the chest". Back then no one had understood it, had ascribed it to the fever. Now it fitted. The faulty spot. Momme. The book. It had been no fever-talk. It had been the truth, which a dying man had not been able to speak and yet had not quite wanted to conceal.

Wiebke sat in the sober archive, with the transcripts before her, and grasped that the depoldering she was planning would lay bare more than just the old sea-floor. It would, when she gave the foreland back to the water and the silt was carried off, perhaps lay bare the sunken Feddersen warft — the place at which her own family had buried a guilt, a hundred years old, embanked like the land itself. And she grasped that she now, as the first in four generations, had the choice that Hauke and Bo had not made: to look or to look away, to name or to conceal.

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Chapter 4 - The Uncovered Foreland

The depoldering works began in autumn, with the preliminary survey: one measured the foreland, mapped the subsoil, determined where the new dyke would run and where the old one would be opened. Wiebke directed it, and it was her work to document the terrain, every metre, and so she came out, into the old foreland, the deep stretch before the dyke that had been left to the water since 1906. At low water, at ebb, the foreland lay bare, a wide, silty watt with channels and salt-meadows, and the survey works, the carrying-off of silt for the borings, laid bare what had long been hidden. At one spot, there where the old dyke had broken in 1906, an excavator struck masonry — old bricks, a foundation, a buried well. The remains of a farmstead that had stood here before the water came.

Wiebke stood before it, in the silt, in rubber boots, and saw the uncovered foundations, and she knew what it was before anyone confirmed it. The Feddersen warft. The farm that went under in 1906, when the dyke broke. Here Momme Feddersen had lived, the man who drowned at the faulty spot of her great-grandfather. Here, beneath the silt of a hundred years, lay the ground on which the history of her family stood.

It was a biologist on the project team who was there that day, a woman in her thirties, who mapped the salt-meadows and accompanied the renaturation, and when the foundations appeared, she came over and looked at them, long, with a face in which something worked. "That was a farm," she said. "Someone lived here

once."

"The Feddersen warft," said Wiebke. "It went under, nineteen-hundred-six. In the dyke breach."

The biologist looked at her. "How do you know that?"

"From the records. I'm Carstens. Wiebke Carstens." She said the name, and she saw how it landed with the other woman, how something changed in her face, grew cooler, more watchful.

"Carstens," said the biologist slowly. "And I'm Lena Feddersen." She let the name stand, between them, in the silt, over the uncovered foundations. "Then we both know, I suppose, that this is no ordinary farm appearing there."

It was the first time the two lines met again, a Carstens and a Feddersen, at the same place, over the sunken warft, a hundred years after the flood that had separated them. And there lay a coldness between them, at once, the old coldness of the village, the not-greeting, of which neither had known the exact ground and which now, over the uncovered stones, got a ground. But beneath the coldness lay also something else, an attention, a recognition that they both knew or sensed something larger than their strangeness, and that this something here, in the silt, was just now coming to light, stone by stone, the way the water gave it up, the water one would now let rise again.

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Chapter 5 - Lena Feddersen

Wiebkke sought Lena Feddersen a few days after the find, not in the watt, but in the village, where Lena lived in an old house that had once belonged to an aunt. Lena was the last of the Feddersens who had returned to the coast; her parents had gone away, into the west, like so many, and Lena had brought back the biology studies and the love of the watt sea, into a place where her name had a history of which she knew only the outlines. "I know there's a history between our families," said Wiebke, when they sat in Lena's kitchen, stiff, full of old coldness. "I didn't know it, until I looked into the records. Now I know it. And I think you should know it too."

She laid the transcripts on the table: the protocol of 1906, the entry from the dyke book, the survey files. Lena read. Wiebke watched her read, saw how the other woman's face changed, from coolness to tension to shock. Lena knew the family legend — that her great-grandfather Momme had drowned in the great flood, in the dyke service, and that the family had impoverished afterward while the Carstenses rose, and that there was something, an old grudge, a suspicion no one could prove any more. It had been a tale, a wound without proof. And now the proof lay before her, black on white, brought by a Carstens.

"A faulty spot," said Lena quietly, reading aloud. "The dyke-reeve warned. A dead man at the said spot." She looked up. "My great-grandfather. He guarded the spot your great-grandfather knew would not hold. And he died for it."

"Yes," said Wiebke. "So I read it too."

"Why do you bring me this?" Lena's voice was no longer cool. "You're a Carstens. This incriminates your own family. Why do you dig it up?"

"Because it's true," said Wiebke. "And because in my family there has been silence for a hundred years. My great-grandfather kept silent. My grandfather kept silent, he lay dying and couldn't get it out. As a child I heard him talk of a faulty spot and of Momme, and no one understood it. Now I understand it. And I can't keep silent any more. That would be the fourth. Four generations of silence. At some point someone has to open their mouth."

Lena sat there, the transcript in her hand, and in her face many things struggled: the old grudge, which now had a proof; the shock that the legend was true; and something unexpected, a reluctant respect for the woman opposite her, the Carstens, who had come to bring her own family's guilt to light.

"What do you want to do?" asked Lena.

"I don't know," said Wiebke honestly. "That's why I'm here. It concerns you as much as me. Perhaps more. I didn't want to decide it over your head. It's the history of your great-grandfather. You should have a say in what becomes of it."

And that, Lena thought, that no Carstens had ever done: let a Feddersen have a say. She put the transcript away, slowly, and said: "I have to think about it." And they parted, the two women, without reconciliation, without enmity, with a shared burden that lay between them like the uncovered stones in the watt, and neither of them knew whether quarrel would come of it or peace, but both knew the silence was over.

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Chapter 6 - Jan at the Dyke

While Wiebke wrestled with the past, Jan fought with the present, and his present was the old dyke, which held and would not hold much longer. On a day in autumn a heavy west wind came up, and with it a raised tide, nothing catastrophic, but enough to tear open a weak spot at the old dyke — seeping water, a softening section, exactly the kind of spot a dyke-man fears. Jan was the first there, and he called, when he could get, and a construction crew came that the water board sent, men with sandbags and gear, and among them was a Romanian worker, one of those who today did the work for which no locals could be found any more, as earlier the Poles and the Turks. They worked together, Jan and the crew, stacked bags, secured the spot, for hours, in the wind and the spraying water, and at the end the dyke held.

And it was, as it always was at the dyke: in the work, in the danger, it did not count where one came from. The Romanian worker took hold like the others, held the bag where Jan needed it, and Jan, who otherwise thought little of incomers, reached him his hand at the end and said "good work", and meant it. It was the old solidarity of the dyke, that did not ask after a passport, the same that had once bound Hauke and Momme, before the one set the other at the faulty spot. Jan lived it, unconsciously, the better part of what his family was, without knowing that his family also knew the worse part.

In the evening, exhausted, Jan sat with Wiebke, who had come to assess the weak spot — for her another proof that the old dyke was not to be held. And Wiebke, tired and full of what she had found in

the records, told him. Of 1906. Of the faulty spot. Of Hauke, who was warned and did not have it repaired. Of Momme Feddersen, who drowned for it. Of the land their farm gained in the process.

Jan listened, and his face closed. "That's a hundred years ago," he said. "What's the point now. They're all dead. Leave the land in peace, Wiebke. Leave the old stories where they are."

"The land won't leave me in peace," said Wiebke. "It comes to light of itself. When we depolder, we lay bare the old foreland, the Feddersen warft, everything. The water gives back what it took, and with the land comes the history. I can't leave it in the silt, Jan. It's already half out."

"So you want to spread it about," said Jan. "Our family at the pillory. The farm, the land — everything we have. You're sawing the branch we sit on."

"I want to name it. Not spread it about. That's a difference." Wiebke looked at her cousin, the preserver, who held the land and the silence, and she saw in him Bo and Hauke, the same attitude, the same holding-on, the same looking-away. "You're like them, Jan. Like the grandfather, like the great-grandfather. Rather hold the land and keep silent than look. But the water is rising, and it takes the land from us anyway. The only question is whether we let the truth be washed out with it or whether we speak it ourselves, honestly."

Jan was silent, and between the cousins ran a crack, fine but distinct, the same crack that ran through the family for a hundred years: between the one who preserves and the one who names. And Wiebke went that evening from Jan's farm without their having come to agreement, and she knew she would have to make the decision alone, or with Lena, but not with Jan, who held the land and the silence, because he could not do otherwise.

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Chapter 7 - Bo's Last Word

Wiebke had known her grandfather Bo only as an old, silent man, at the edge of her childhood, for he had died when she was still young. But she had a memory, a single one, that now, since she knew the records, took on its sense, and she brought it forth like a piece of evidence one has long laid aside. It had been at his deathbed. The family had come together, to the coast, for the farewell, and Wiebke, then a girl of perhaps twelve, had gone with her mother into the room where the grandfather lay, at the window from which one saw the dyke. Bo had talked confused stuff, the grown-ups had said, fever, the end. But Wiebke, the child, had listened, the way children listen, and remembered what the grown-ups wiped away.

Bo had talked of Henryk. "I shouldn't have set him at the spot," he had said, again and again, "not at the spot at the weir. He pulled me from the ice, and I set him at the weir." And then of a "faulty spot", and of "Momme", and of a "book in the chest", and once, quite clearly all of a sudden, in the midst of the confusion: "It all lies in the land. Don't dig it up. Or dig it up. Someone has to speak it, once."

Back then no one had understood it. Now Wiebke understood. Henryk — that had been the forced labourer of whom the farm's records said nothing, of whom only this dying sentence testified: that Bo had set him at a dangerous spot, a man who had saved his life. And the faulty spot, Momme, the book — that was the other guilt, the older one, the great-grandfather Hauke's. Bo had known both, at the end, the father's and his own, and he had not been able to speak

them and yet had not quite wanted to conceal them, and so he had left them to a child, in confused words the child remembered.

"Don't dig it up. Or dig it up. Someone has to speak it, once." That had been Bo's last word, the whole contradiction of a man who knew the truth and could not bear it, who wanted to be rid of it and keep it at once. It was no commission, not directly; it was the burden itself, passed on, with the plea to do something with it that he had not managed.

Wiebke sat in her room at the inn, with the records and the memory, and she grasped that she was now the last who knew everything — the old guilt from the records, the younger from Bo's dying word — and the first who could freely decide, because no one lived any more whom the truth would bring down, and no one any more who kept silent. Hauke had kept silent and passed it on. Bo had known it and not got it out and passed it on. And now it lay with her, and she felt the weight of a hundred years, and she knew what Bo had meant: that someone had to speak it, once, and that she was that one, whether she wanted to or not.

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Chapter 8 - What to Do with It

Wiebke and Lena met again, this time in Lena's kitchen, and they wrestled with the question that had no easy answer: what does one do with a truth that benefits no one any more and harms no one any more, because all who are concerned are dead? "For a hundred years my great-grandfather has counted as the one who simply had bad luck, who drowned in a natural catastrophe. And the truth is that he died because a Carstens saved at the wrong end. That belongs in the light. That's the least one owes him."

Wiebke was more cautious. "What good does it do him? He's been dead a hundred years. No scandal rehabilitates him any more."

"It does his memory good. His descendants. The truth."

"And it shames mine," said Wiebke. "My cousin Jan, who can do nothing about it. And perhaps it shames more than just us. Whoever in this marsh has come up a little, over the generations, has perhaps also saved at the wrong end sometime, looked away, taken an advantage where another lost. If we open this up, where does it stop?"

She was tempted, Wiebke felt it, tempted to let it rest. It would have been so easy. No one knew the records except her and Lena. She could lay them back, carry the plan through technically, flood the foreland, and the old story would stay where it had lain a hundred years: in the silt, under water. It was the same temptation that had bound her great-grandfather and brought her grandfather to silence, and Wiebke recognised it: it worked not through threat but through

reason, through the quiet voice that says it is better for everyone to let the heavy rest. So all the Carstenses had kept silent. So the marsh kept silent about so much. Silence was cheap, and speech was dear, and Wiebke understood for the first time fully why four generations had chosen the cheap.

She chose the dear. But she chose it her way, not Lena's.

"I won't make it a scandal," she said. "No opening-up, no accusing, no pillory. Nothing gets better from that, it only breeds new grudge, and our families have had grudge long enough. But neither do I bury it. That's the third way, Lena, between the silence and the scandal: we name it. We give the truth where it belongs. There'll be a chronicle, for the depoldering, for the history of the koog — and there's to be a memorial plaque at the uncovered place, at the Feddersen warft. That's where it belongs, all of it: the flood of nineteen-hundred-six, the faulty spot, the death of your great-grandfather, with names, certified, readable. Not hidden and not blown up into a scandal. Simply true. Simply there. Whoever wants to know it can read it. No one who doesn't want to has to. But it is no longer hidden."

Lena thought a long time. "That's less than I wanted," she said at last.

"I know. But it's more than any Carstens ever admitted. And it's what I can carry without doing new harm. Momme Feddersen gets his name back, with the truth, in the chronicle, on the plaque, forever. And Hauke Carstens gets his too, beside it, with what he did. Both names, both truths. That's justice, as far as I can give it."

And Lena, after a long silence, nodded. "Good," she said. "I'll go that way with you. But we do it together, Wiebke. A Feddersen and a Carstens. So no one can say it's the revenge of the one or the

whitewash of the other."

"Together," said Wiebke, and they shook hands, a Carstens and a Feddersen, for the first time in a hundred years, over the table on which the records lay, and it was no reconciliation, not yet, but it was the beginning of something larger than the enmity they had inherited, and smaller than the forgiveness neither of them had to give: a shared looking, a shared naming, the end of the silence.

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Chapter 9 - The Koog Speaks

Wiebke laid both before them, in the same week: the depoldering plan with the unavoidable opening of the old dyke, in the village hall, before the whole koog, and, as part of the accompanying chronicle, the historical truth about the flood of 1906, which she and Lena had written down together, soberly, with evidence, without accusation. The town meeting was full, for it was about land, about home, about the future of the koog, and that brought the people, as it always brought them. Wiebke explained the plan: the new dyke inland, the opening of the old one, the foreland given back to the sea and to nature conservation. She explained the necessity, the rising level, the costs, the safety. And she saw that she met resistance, the anger of those who would lose land, Jan above all, and the deeper aversion of a kind of people whose whole history was reclaimed land and for whom giving up land was like a defeat.

And then, when it came to the chronicle, to the history of the koog one wanted to publish for the depoldering, Wiebke brought the other matter to speech: that the flood of 1906 had not been only an act of God, that there had been a known faulty spot, a warning, an omission, and a dead man who died for it. She named the names, both: Momme Feddersen, who drowned, and Hauke Carstens, the dyke-reeve, who had not had the spot done. Her own great-grandfather.

The koog did not react with the outcry Lena had perhaps expected and feared. It reacted with the old reflex of the marsh: with silence,

with embarrassment, with the wish not to stir up. The chairman of the dyke association spoke of a "historical matter that had to be sorted out factually". A few old people who still knew or sensed something came later to Wiebke, quietly, at the door, in the street, and said it was good it was out, their grandparents had always muttered something of the flood and the Carstenses and the Feddersens, and never had anyone spoken it. Others turned away. Some Carstens relatives, distant ones, no longer greeted Wiebke. Jan sat in the meeting with a closed face and said nothing.

It was no sensation, no scandal, and precisely that Wiebke had wanted. But it was also no redemption, no moment in which the silence broke and the koog breathed out. It was more sober, more laborious: an old truth was named, took its place in the chronicle, and life went on, a little different, a little more honest. Lena stood beside Wiebke as the meeting dissolved, and said: "I'd have thought it would feel different. Bigger." And Wiebke said: "So did I. But perhaps that's all there is. Not one great moment. Only the end of the concealing."

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Chapter 10 - The Opening of the Dyke

The following autumn the new dyke was finished, a stretch inland, higher and stronger than the old one, built to the gauges of the future, not the past. And then came the day on which the old dyke was opened. It was no breach, no catastrophe, but the opposite: a controlled opening, planned, measured, with excavators and calculation. One dug away the old dyke at one spot, let the water flow in controlled, at a middling tide, so it did not shoot but rose, slowly, and spread over the old foreland, the deep stretch that for a hundred years had been wrested from the water or left to the water.

Wiebke directed it, as an engineer, and she experienced it at once as a descendant, and the two would not be separated. She stood at the new dyke and saw the water flow in, there where in 1906 the water had broken in, only this time not in the storm, not killing, but planned, taken into service. The sea reclaimed what one had taken from it — but this time the human gave it, instead of losing it. That was the difference, and it was a great one: not the breach, but the giving-back; not the omission, but the decision.

Jan was there. He had fought against the depoldering to the last, and he had lost, and now he stood at the dyke and saw his foreland flood, the land his forebears had won, the best land of the farm. It was a hard farewell, and Wiebke saw what it cost him, and she said nothing, for there was nothing to say that would have made it easier. Jan watched the water as it rose, over the ditches, over the old field boundaries, over the spot where the Feddersen warft lay, and his face

was stony, and then, after a long time, he said, quietly, almost to himself: "My grandfather always said the land doesn't forget. Now it forgets after all. It goes under water, and in twenty years no one knows there was land here."

"It doesn't go under, Jan," said Wiebke. "It becomes watt. It becomes salt-meadow. It lives on differently. And it doesn't forget — we've seen to it that it doesn't forget. It's in the chronicle. It goes on the plaque. The history stays, even when the land becomes water."

Jan did not answer. He watched the rising water until it reached the spot where the sunken warft lay, and covered it again, the stones one had uncovered, the well, the foundations — the sea reclaimed them, gently this time, and laid itself over them, smooth and grey. Out of the secret that had lain a hundred years in the silt, that one had brought to light and named, became again water and watt, tides, geology. Finished. And Wiebke thought that perhaps it was right so: that one first uncovered the truth, named it, wrote it into the chronicle — and then gave it back to the water, not as concealing, but as peace, as a land that finally went honestly under water.

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Chapter 11 - Reconciliation

The chronicle appeared in winter, a slim volume, published for the depoldering of the Sankt-Annen-Koog, and in it stood, in a chapter on the great storm tide of 1906, the truth that Wiebke and Lena had written down together, soberly, with evidence, without triumph and without whitewash. It stood in it that the dyke had broken in 1906 at a spot known to be faulty; that the dyke-reeve had been warned and the repair had been left undone out of thrift; that at this spot a man drowned who guarded it, Momme Feddersen; and that the dyke-reeve was called Hauke Carstens. Both names. Momme Feddersen, who was no longer only a victim of misfortune, but a man who died for another's omission. Hauke Carstens, named with what he had done and concealed. The truth, black on white, for anyone who wished to read it.

And there was a memorial plaque. At the new dyke, there where one looked over the depoldered foreland, beneath which the Feddersen warft now lay again under water, one set a plain plaque, and on it stood the name Momme Feddersen, and the year, and a sentence Wiebke and Lena had chosen together: He guarded the dyke that others left to him.

They stood together at the plaque when it was set, Wiebke and Lena, in the cold wind, and looked over the water that now covered the old land.

"I can't forgive you what your family did to mine," said Lena. "That's not for me. Momme would have to forgive, and Momme has

been dead a hundred years. And honestly, I don't want to forgive you either, for forgiveness would be too easy."

"I don't want forgiveness," said Wiebke. "I've done nothing I'd need to ask forgiveness for, and for what my great-grandfather did no one can forgive me, because it isn't mine. I only wanted it named. That it stops being hidden. No more."

"That's enough," said Lena. "That's more than I'd ever have expected from a Carstens." And she looked at Wiebke, and in her gaze there was not forgiveness and not enmity, but something new that had never existed between Carstens and Feddersen: respect. "You know what's strange? My brother and your cousin Jan's daughter. They know each other, from school, over in the county town. They're friends, they say. Perhaps more." She smiled, for the first time. "A Feddersen and a Carstens. Imagine."

"Imagine," said Wiebke, and she too smiled, and over the depoldered land, beneath which the old warft and the old guilt now lay honestly under water, the two women shook hands, a Carstens and a Feddersen, and it was no final stroke and no grand reconciliation, but something simpler and more durable: the end of an enmity no one would inherit any more, because the next generation was already overcoming it, without much ado, the way children overcome things that seemed insurmountable to the old.

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Chapter 12 - The Last Tide at the Old Dyke

The first heavy spring tide after the opening came in February, and it flooded the depoldered foreland full, higher than it had ever stood beneath the old dyke. Wiebke and Jan stood at the new dyke and watched the water rise, over the old land, over the ditches, over the spot where the warft lay, until the whole foreland was a grey, moving surface, sea, where for a hundred years there had been land. It was a strange hour, one in which something came to an end. The old koog, as three, four generations had known it, had grown smaller; a piece of itself was now sea again. And yet it was no going-under, no breach, no catastrophe like 1906. It was an orderly retreat, a decision, and the new dyke held the water, there where one could and had to hold it.

"The birds are coming," said Jan after a while, almost reluctantly. He had resisted the depoldering to the last, but he was farmer enough to see what was happening: already in the first weeks life had come into the new watt, waders, ducks, and in summer the salt-meadows would bloom, and it would be another fertility than that of the marsh, a wilder, older one. "My grandfather couldn't have borne it," said Jan. "Land one gives back to the water. For him the land was everything."

"Perhaps," said Wiebke. "But perhaps he'd also have understood that the water always wins in the end, and that it's wiser to give it in order than to lose everything uncontrolled. He fought the water all his life. Perhaps he'd have known when a fight is no longer to be won."

They stood in silence, and the water rose, and Wiebke thought of all who had been here: of Hauke, who concealed the dyke and gained; of Momme, who drowned for it; of Bo, who inherited the guilt and repeated it; of Henryk, the foreigner, who died for another; of Thies, who carried the bitterness; of Antje and Grete, the women who knew everything and kept silent. They all had been here, at this dyke, at this water, and they all were gone, and the land they had held and lost and regained now went under water, honestly this time, with their names in the chronicle, on the plaque.

"That's the last tide at the old dyke," said Wiebke. "From now on only the new one counts." And she saw how the water washed over the last remnant of the old dyke, which now lay useless in the watt, a wall that protected nothing any more, a piece of the past the sea reclaimed. The koog, as it had been, ceased to be, and another began, smaller, more honest, with a piece of sea where there had been land, and a truth where there had been silence.

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Chapter 13 - The Dyke Book, Read

There was still the dyke book. Wiebke had not forgotten it — Bo's dying word of the "book in the chest", the transcript in the board archive, which was only an excerpt. The original, the old, leather-bound dyke book that Okke Nissen had kept and Hauke had taken over and Bo had inherited, that had to be still on the farm, in the chest, if no one had thrown it away. She asked Jan for it. It cost a conversation, for Jan wanted to let the old story rest, but in the end he went up to the attic and brought down the chest, and in the chest, under leases and yellowed letters, it lay: the dyke book, heavy, leather-bound, a hundred years of dyke history. Wiebke opened it, with careful hands, and found the page of 1906, Okke's hand, the entry about the faulty spot, the warning, the dead man. There it was, the original, which Hauke had not torn out, which Bo had not destroyed, which both had left standing, for a hundred years, unread, for the one who would come.

"They didn't destroy it," said Wiebke quietly. "My great-grandfather didn't and my grandfather didn't. They could have torn out the page. No one would have noticed. But they left it standing."

"Why?" asked Jan, who looked over her shoulder.

"I think because they hoped," said Wiebke. "Not aloud, not even admitted to themselves. But they kept the book, passed it on, with the entry in it. As if they had known they were themselves too cowardly to speak it, and hoped that one day someone would come who was not. They didn't erase the truth. They only let it lie, for later. For us."

She handed the dyke book to the county archive, certified, as a historical document, openly accessible. The entry of 1906, unread for a hundred years, was now read, sorted in, part of the documented history of the koog. What Hauke had concealed and Bo had not dared to speak was now named, certified, accessible — no secret any more, only history.

And then Wiebke went one last time out to the new dyke, to the memorial plaque, and looked over the water that now stood over the sunken warft, over the spot where Momme had died, where the guilt had been buried. The water reclaimed it, gently, tide by tide. Out of the secret became again water and watt, tides, a name on a plaque, a page in a book in the archive. Finished. The guilt was not expunged — Hauke was still the one who had saved, Momme still the one who died. But it was named, brought to light, and then given back to the water, not as concealing, but as peace. And that, Wiebke thought, was all a human being could do: not change the past, only stop burying it.

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Chapter 14 - What the Sea Reclaims

The depoldering at the Sankt-Annen-Koog became a model. Other sections of the threatened coast looked to it, for the problem was everywhere the same: the sea level was rising, the old dykes were not to be held in the long run, and at some point one had to choose where to fight and where to yield. Wiebke was asked, here and there, advised other projects, and she saw that what had happened at the Sankt-Annen-Koog was the beginning of something larger: a rethinking, a different relation to the water, no longer only the struggle for every metre of land, but a giving and taking, a living with the sea instead of only against it. While at one place an old land was given back to the sea, one built elsewhere new, higher dykes, secured what could be secured. They were two movements at once, the yielding and the strengthening, and both belonged together, both were answers to the same rising water. The coast Wiebke knew was no longer the coast of her forebears; it was in transformation, would transform further, and no one knew exactly how it would look in a hundred years, how much land would remain, how much would become water.

The family, no longer bound to the old soil, scattered further. Jan stayed on the farm, smaller now, without the foreland, but he stayed, for he was a preserver and could not do otherwise. His daughter, though, who was friends with a Feddersen, would perhaps go away, or stay, no one knew. Wiebke herself did not belong here, not any more; she had her life elsewhere, her work along the whole coast, and the Sankt-Annen-Koog was for her now a place of origin, not of

home.

It was an ambivalent freedom. For a hundred years the family had clung to this land, to this farm, to this dyke, bound by possession, by duty, by the *Spadelandsrecht*, by the guilt that lay in the soil. And now the bond was loosed: the foreland was water, the truth was named, the old office of the dyke-reeve no longer existed in that form. The family was free — and freedom was also loss. Whoever is no longer bound to a land has it easier and has less hold. Wiebke felt both, when she thought of the coast that was no longer hers and yet would always remain a part of her.

She stood, on one of her last days at the *koog*, on the new dyke and looked over the transformed land: the depoldered foreland, now watt and salt-meadow, full of birds; the old dyke, half decayed, washed over by the sea; the *warften* that still stood, smaller surrounded by water. And she thought that the sea reclaimed what one had taken from it, slowly, patient, over generations, and that it was wiser to understand that than to dyke against it forever. The water rose. The coast remained a task. But it was a more honest task now, one that no longer saw the water only as an enemy, but as what it was: the element out of which this land had come and into which it would return, sooner or later, whether one kept silent or spoke.

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Chapter 15 - What Remains When the Land Sinks

The years that followed changed the Sankt-Annen-Koog more slowly than one had feared, and more deeply. The depoldered foreland became a blooming watt biotope, a protected area, into which the birds came in their thousands, in which the salt-meadows stood violet with sea-lavender in summer. Where for a hundred years land had been wrested from the sea, the land now gave back, and it was not poorer for it, only different, another kind of fertility, a wilder one. Wiebke still came back sometimes, on account of the work, of the plaque, sometimes on account of Lena, with whom a kind of friendship had grown, cautious, over the shared burden. She would then go out onto the new dyke, from which one overlooked the whole transformed land, and look over the watt, over the warften, over the sea, and think about what had happened.

For this she had learned, in those years: that it was not the truth that redeemed. She had brought the truth to light, named her great-grandfather's omission, connected the name of Momme Feddersen with the truth, broken the hundred-year silence. And she had half believed that would redeem something, take a burden from the family, bring a peace. But it was not so. The truth redeemed nothing. Hauke was still the one who had saved; Bo the one who repeated it; Momme and Henryk stayed dead, the guilt stayed guilt, no naming made that un-happen.

What had changed was one single thing, and Wiebke grasped only late that it was enough: one had stopped concealing. One had stopped holding the water over the land, the truth behind the dyke. For four generations the family and with it the whole koog had concealed a sunken matter, embanked, inherited; and now, with the concealed named and the land given back to the water, one could finally breathe out. Not relieved, not happy, not redeemed. Only honest.

And that, Wiebke thought, from the new dyke, over the given-back land, that was perhaps all a human being could achieve: not to expunge the guilt that could not be expunged, not to wake the dead, but only to stop hiding them. The solidarity Hauke had betrayed, when he set Momme at the faulty spot, was not dead; it had only changed its form, from the dyke watch into memory, from the struggle against the water into the shared living with it. Hauke, Momme, Bo, Henryk — they all got what was possible, the only thing Wiebke could give them: a name, no verdict. They were named, all of them, with their guilt and their loyalty, and they were no longer hidden, and that was the legacy that held when the land sank: the truth, spoken, and the breath, finally let go.

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Chapter 16 - High and Low Waters

Years later, on a clear day in early summer, a woman walked over the new dyke, and with her went a child she held by the hand and who plagued her with questions, the way children do. The woman was Wiebke, older now, and the child was a great-nephew, or a great-niece — the families had mingled, Carstens and Feddersen, for Jan's daughter had married Lena's brother, and out of the two lines that had not greeted each other for a hundred years, one had become. The child holding Wiebke's hand carried both names in itself, without knowing it, and knew nothing of the old story, and that was the best of it: that for this child it was a matter of course, what the old had paid for with guilt and silence.

"What's that, Aunt Wiebke?" asked the child, and pointed out where the watt stretched, wide and gleaming at low water, with the channels and the flocks of birds.

"That used to be land," said Wiebke. "People lived there, long ago, and tilled fields, behind a dyke. And then it was decided to give the land back to the sea, because the water is rising and one could no longer hold it. Now it's watt. Now the birds live there."

"And the people?"

"They moved away. Or died, long ago." Wiebke pointed to the plaque at the dyke. "You see the plaque? There's a name on it. Momme Feddersen. He lived here, and he drowned in a great flood, over a hundred years ago. So that he isn't forgotten, his name is there."

The child spelled out the name, and then looked again at the watt. "Was it nice, before? With the land?"

Wiebke considered. It was a child's question, and it demanded a true answer. "It was hard," she said. "The people wrested the land from the sea, with their hands, generation by generation. And much wrong happened in the process, before. People looked away, saved at the wrong end, kept silent where they should have spoken. In our family too." She paused. "But there was something good there too. When the flood came, everyone helped everyone at the dyke, no matter who. That was called solidarity. That was the nicest thing about it, and it held, longer than the land."

"Do we hold together too?" asked the child.

"I hope so," said Wiebke. "I hope so very much."

They stood a moment and looked over the watt, the older woman and the child, and the wind went over the dyke, from the west, as it had always gone, and the water began to rise, for the tide was coming, as it came twice a day, since the world began. And Wiebke thought of all who had been here: of Hauke, who concealed, and Momme, who drowned; of Bo, who looked away, and Henryk, who died for him; of Antje and Grete and Thies and Lena and of herself, who had broken the silence. They all had been here, at this water, and they all were gone, and the land they had struggled over was now sea, and over the sea flew the birds, and on land a child held her hand and knew the story not as a wound, but would one day hear it as history, honestly, with guilt and with loyalty, and do better, perhaps, than the old.

"Come," said Wiebke, and took the child more firmly by the hand. "The water's coming. We have to get off the watt before the flood's here." And they went back, over the dyke, inland, away from the

rising water, and behind them the watt filled, high and low waters, ebb and flood, the giving and taking of the sea, which had no end and no beginning, and which now, after a hundred years, concealed nothing any more, but only breathed, high water and low, over a land that no longer held the guilt fast.

Über dieses Buch

The Reclaimed Land - Depoldering

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